Research Proposal

Title:

Research in enhancing the service of red mini-bus for passenger satisfaction: strategies and suggestions

Research questions：

Main question:

How can the red minibus system be improved to enhance passenger satisfaction?

Sub questions:

What is the passengers' perception of the current operation of the red minibus system?

What are the reasons behind passengers' dissatisfaction with taking red minibuses?

What are the current difficulties faced by red minibus owners in their endeavours to enhance customer satisfaction?

Introduction:

As a type of semi-collective transport, minibuses in Hong Kong are somewhere between regular buses and private taxis. Minibuses in Hong Kong are vans, with a capacity of 16 people (no standing tickets). Minibuses can flexibly shuttle among traffic, creating miraculous economic benefits and becoming a major feature of Hong Kong. Minibuses operate on the assumption that there are approximately 12 to 16 people wanting to travel to the same location at the same time. Minibuses are cheaper and faster than taxis, especially during rush hour traffic. Unlike designated bus routes, minibus routes are highly arbitrary. You can stop at any point on the route as long as it is not a particularly prohibited location. Minibuses are available all over Hong Kong Island,

including Kowloon and the outskirts of the New Territories, and are open to traffic around the clock. Minibus networks include more intermediate stops, i.e. locations that are rarely directly reached by major transport lines, thus filling the gap between mass transport and taxis. The biggest advantage of minibuses is that they can get passengers to their destinations faster than any other public transport facility.

Today, there are still two types of minibuses in Hong Kong. They are under different management systems and have different operating methods and business models. In addition to regular routes and time settings, green minibuses also have fixed and open fare standards like buses. Completely market and passenger oriented, the red minibuses represents the true essence of Hong Kong's minibuses. They do not have fixed routes or timetables, so there is freedom to choose routes, take detours, or take passengers closer to their destinations. Red minibuses drivers are notorious for driving fast and arbitrarily. They are self-employed, either as personal assets or leased from large companies. Therefore, they are more motivated and driving faster means more miles traveled and more income.

Objectives:

This research aims to evaluate red minibus services from the perspectives of passengers and potential passengers. The study will examine safety measures, passengers' perceptions of safety, comfort factors such as seating and air conditioning, convenience aspects like frequency and accessibility, and cultural influences on passengers' experiences. By identifying challenges and providing recommendations for improvement, the research aims to enhance the overall quality and effectiveness of red minibus services.

Methods:

The research methods proposed for gathering information from passengers during field trips include surveys, questionnaires, observations, and interviews. These methods aim to collect data on passengers' experiences and perceptions of red minibus services.

Surveys and questionnaires will be distributed to passengers, allowing them to provide feedback on various aspects such as safety, comfort, convenience, and cultural differences. This quantitative data will provide valuable insights into passenger satisfaction and areas for improvement.

Observations will be conducted on selected mini-bus routes, focusing on both drivers and passengers. This will involve observing driver behavior, adherence to safety measures, and interactions with passengers. Additionally, passenger behavior and their experiences during the journey will be observed to gain a deeper understanding of their perspectives.

Interviews will be conducted with a sample of passengers to gather qualitative data. These interviews will provide an opportunity for passengers to express their thoughts, opinions, and suggestions regarding red minibus services. The interviews will be structured to cover topics such as safety, comfort, convenience, and cultural influences. At the same time, some red minibus operators will also be interviewed to understand the development status and difficulties of the red minibus industry from the perspective of operators, and to understand their attitudes and opinions on the services currently provided and passengers' feedback on the services.

In addition to the proposed methods, an extra method involves dividing the research team into two groups. One group will set up boarding points and destinations, while the other group observes the behavior of passengers during

the journey. This method allows for real-time observation of passenger behavior and interactions within the red minibus environment.

By employing these research methods, the study aims to gather comprehensive and diverse data to evaluate red minibus services from the perspectives of passengers. The combination of quantitative and qualitative data will provide a holistic understanding of the strengths and weaknesses of the services, enabling the formulation of effective recommendations for improvement.

Timeline:

Task	**Time**
Define research objectives and questions	4 Sep - 18 Step
Conduct literature review	18 Sep -25 Step
Identify research methodologies	10 Oct - 25 Oct
Begin data collection	6 Nov - 16 Nov
Complete data collection	17 Nov
Analyze collected data	18 Nov -21 Nov
Interpret result and finding	18 Nov -21 Nov
Draft research report	22 Nov - 25 Nov
Finalize research report	25 Nov - 15 Dec

Expected Outcome:

Our research has multiple important objectives. Firstly, we aim to identify passenger perceptions of the current operation of the red minibus system. We also seek to understand the underlying causes of passenger dissatisfaction.

Additionally, we strive to explore the challenges encountered by red minibus owners in operating the system and making necessary improvements. This will provide a deeper understanding of the operational difficulties they face.
Lastly, we will generate valuable insights and recommendations that can be utilized to enhance the overall performance and satisfaction of the red minibus system.